



terms of people being able to play in different positions. We also got closer to the better teams in the world," the Dutchwoman added. After its Olympic debut in 1980, the Indian women's hockey team qualified for the Summer Games for the first time in 2016. However, that campaign in Rio de Janeiro ended with the team finishing last in the group stage.

Schopman joined the Indian team as the analytical coach in January 2020 and watched it achieve a historic fourth-place finish under compatriot Sjoerd Marijne's guidance at the Tokyo Olympics in 2021. She took over as head coach after Marijne's departure and led India to its first medal at the Commonwealth Games in 16 years. The team also finished third in the 2021-22 Pro League and won the inaugural FIH Nations Cup.

Schopman is well aware of the shift in how others look at the current

Indian team. "We were the underdogs and a surprise four years ago. Unfortunately, we don't have that luck this time. All the other teams know who we are and that we can play some really good hockey. This presents a different challenge for us as a team and for me as a coach," she said.

Playing in front of home fans in Ranchi should act as a massive boost, but it also brings added pressure with it, something that Savita admits. This is where the side's mental fortitude will be tested.

"We are working on certain aspects, but of course, there will be

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pressure. How we can manage that pressure is something we have been working on because it is an event of huge significance," said Savita, who recently won a third consecutive FIH Women's Goalkeeper of the Year Award. Peter Harberl, appointed as the mental conditioning coach in October, will have an important role to play on the sidelines in Ranchi.

In the absence of Rani Rampal and Gurjit Kaur, a lot will depend on the experience of Savita, who'll lead young stars like Sangita Kumari and Salima Tete.

However, the team has suffered a minor setback as experienced forward Vandana Katariya, initially named vice-captain, has been ruled out of the tournament due to injury.

Schopman knows the different challenges her team will face in the group stage. "New Zealand is a hard-working team. They'll never give up. The USA is the same. Italy is a bit like Argentina, a team that won't go away. They're a little bit annoying," she said.

"Our penalty corners and defensive structure will be important. With our attacking skills, we should be able to create good opportunities and convert them as well."

Four years ago, Marijne's India beat Schopman's USA 6-5 in a thrilling two-match series to qualify for the Tokyo Olympics.

As fate would have it, India's Olympic dreams are once again directly linked to the Dutchwoman.